

# **Feasibility as a Parameter: When Comparative International Research on Narrow Specialist Professional Populations Can and Cannot Be Executed**

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## **Abstract**

Comparative international business research assumes it can reach the same population in every country in a design. For narrow specialist professional populations that assumption fails in a way the literature reports as a limitation after the fact. This paper argues it is a parameter that can be estimated before a study is fielded. A reachable usable sample is modelled as the product of frame size, specialist prevalence, response rate and screen survival, each decided at a different level of analysis. Because a comparative claim is a conjunction, joint feasibility is set by the least feasible national frame, not the average, and adding a frame can only leave it unchanged or lower it. Four further hypotheses draw on regionalization theory, born-regional internationalization, levels-of-analysis research and control-versus-coordination work to predict where specialist prevalence concentrates and why standardization costs most in the frames that already bind. The design reads reachable counts from panel providers' own audience-configuration interfaces, before any commitment, across a matrix of occupations, national frames and providers. A documented case in which a panel of 334,976 yielded roughly twenty eligible participants validates the model. No data have yet been collected for the study proposed.

Keywords: comparative research design; specialist populations; sampling feasibility; regionalization; levels of analysis; survey methodology; response rates

## **The problem**

Comparative international business research rests on a requirement that is rarely stated as a requirement. To compare a phenomenon across countries, a researcher must reach the same population in every country in the design, at the same time, with an instrument that means the same thing in each place. Even in a region such as Latin America, which is more homogeneous than most, researchers must take efforts to adapt their research instruments to differences in language, culture and other variables. For example, Hermans et al. (2017) needed to adapt their survey instrument to variations in Spanish across the region. When the population is a general one, this requirement is demanding but routine, as in the Latin America example above. When the population is a narrow professional specialty, it becomes something else. This paper is about what that something else is, and about the fact that it can be calculated in advance rather than discovered after the money is spent.

The received wisdom treats sampling difficulty as an execution problem. It belongs to fieldwork, to budget, to the quality of local partners, and it surfaces in published work as a limitation paragraph near the end of the method section. The methodological literature on international survey research is considerably more sophisticated than that, and Harzing, Reiche and Pudelko (2013) document response variation across national frames in detail, but its orientation is managerial. Cross-national variation is a nuisance to be reduced through better translation, better incentives, better contact protocols, and better local relationships. The implicit model is that

effort and money convert into responses at a rate that differs by country but is always positive and always improvable.

### **The model and the hypotheses**

The theoretical logic does not depend on any citation and should be clear without one. A comparative claim is a conjunction. To say that a relationship differs between Spain and China is to assert something about Spain and something about China, and the assertion fails if either component fails. The design therefore requires that every frame clear its threshold simultaneously. An average cannot satisfy a conjunction. A design with one excellent frame and one hopeless frame has a respectable mean and no comparison.

*Hypothesis 1: In a comparative design that requires a minimum usable sample in every national frame, joint feasibility is determined by the least feasible frame rather than by the mean across frames, and adding a national frame leaves joint feasibility unchanged or lowers it.*

*Hypothesis 2: The observable prevalence of a narrow specialist professional population on a commercial research panel is higher within the panel provider's home region than outside it, controlling for the size of the national frame.*

*Hypothesis 3: Published studies that describe themselves as cross-national achieve national coverage that is more regionally concentrated than their stated design implies, and the discrepancy increases with the narrowness of the target population.*

*Hypothesis 4: Variance in achieved response attributable to data-collection mode exceeds variance attributable to country.*

*Hypothesis 5: The degree of instrument standardization across national frames is negatively associated with achieved response rate, and the association is stronger in frames with lower baseline response.*

## **Method**

The empirical setting is the set of commercial research panels used in academic and commercial survey work, and the specialist professional occupations that comparative business research targets. The setting is unusual in one respect that makes the study possible. Panel providers expose an audience-configuration interface that returns an estimated reachable count once screening criteria are entered, before any commitment is made and at no cost. The quantity this study needs as its dependent variable is therefore observable in advance and is quotable, rather than having to be inferred from completed studies. This is what makes feasibility a parameter rather than a limitation, and it is the practical basis of the whole project.

The study has three levels of analysis, and stating them matters because the model attributes each term to a different one. The unit is the country-panel-occupation cell: one specialist occupation, on one panel provider, in one national frame. Cells are nested within national frames, frames are nested within regions, and providers are cross-classified with frames because one provider operates in several. The sampling plan is to populate a matrix of at least six specialist occupations across at least eight national frames on at least three panel providers of differing regional origin, which gives a target of roughly one hundred and forty-four cells. Panel providers are selected to vary on home region deliberately, because H2 is unidentifiable if every provider originates in the same place.

## Why this matters for Latin America and the Caribbean

Latin American and Caribbean research is where these constraints bite first. Comparative work on the region is usually multi-country by necessity, because single national samples of managers or professionals are small, and the region's economies differ widely in size. A design that pairs Brazil or Mexico with smaller economies in Central America or the Caribbean will be bound, under H1, by the smallest frame, and for a narrow specialist population that frame may hold only a handful of reachable people. The region's pooled designs are therefore more exposed to the binding-frame effect than their overall sample sizes suggest.

## Contribution

The principal theoretical contribution is to reposition sampling feasibility as a parameter of a comparative design rather than a limitation of a completed one. This changes what is knowable and when. A parameter is estimated in advance and constrains the design space; a limitation is a retrospective account of why a design did not work. The paper supplies the identity that links the observable quantities to reachable sample and demonstrates that the quantities are available before commitment.

|    | <b>Hypothesis</b>                                                                                                                                                        | <b>Theoretical source</b>       | <b>Test</b>                                                      |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| H1 | Joint feasibility is set by the least feasible frame, not the mean; adding a frame weaker than the current minimum lowers it; adding any other frame leaves it unchanged | Analytic; conjunction structure | Demonstration plus sensitivity analysis over the parameter space |
| H2 | Specialist prevalence on a panel is higher inside the provider's home region                                                                                             | Rugman & Verbeke (2004)         | Hierarchical model; region concordance indicator                 |
| H3 | Studies described as cross-national achieve                                                                                                                              | Lopez, Kundu & Ciravegna (2009) | Coverage discrepancy index across published                      |

|    |                                                                                |                             |                                                  |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
|    | regionally concentrated coverage, increasing with population narrowness        |                             | studies                                          |
| H4 | Mode explains more variance in response than country does                      | Meyer, Li & Schotter (2020) | Variance decomposition across levels             |
| H5 | Standardization is negatively associated with response, more so in weak frames | Zeng et al. (2023)          | Standardization by baseline-response interaction |

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